

to hold a conference of vice-chancellors (v-cs) and prepare an action plan. State Cabinet Secretary Shashank Shekhar Singh says that the state Government is equally concerned about the financial problems in the universities and soon an action plan would be announced to make them financially independent. "One should also look into the reasons behind the growing financial burden on the universities. Certain v-cs have appointed hundreds of people without any post. Some, according to reports received by the Government, were involved in illegal money making. So the Government is not solely responsible for the decay on these campuses," says Shekhar, hinting at initiating strict action against certain v-cs.

If the state is blaming the v-cs, it should also look into the selection process and those involved in it. This is a record of sorts in the state as it would be the first time that more than a dozen v-cs have faced inquiries, disciplinary action, arrests and imprisonment on various charges, which also include alleged involvement in murder. The G.B. Patnaik Committee looked into it and found that certain universities are running illegal fashion and beauty courses in the name of tele-education.

The criminal neglect of the state Government in lifting the freeze on grants to the universities has on the one hand dealt a severe blow to the teaching and scientific community and stalled the pace of research and development work. The laboratories are lying deserted, while the agricultural farms have withered. The productivity of the land has already hit rock bottom and though scientists of the universities have worked hard to introduce new techniques and seeds to increase productivity, a prolonged strike would severely hit the farmers in particular and all citizens in general.

A Planning Commission document



"We were compelled to go on strike only because our demands were ignored for so many years."

DR RAM PRATAP SINGH, President, NDATU



**NURSERIES AND LABORATORIES
WITHERING AWAY AT NDATU**

has expressed concern over the state's slow progress in meeting its future target. "By 2012, the state would require about 476 lakh metric tonnes of grain keeping in view the growth of 5.1 per cent in foodgrain consumption," states the document. It has also reminded the state about strengthening its universities and research and development in order to make full use of the state's potential in agriculture, horticulture and fisheries.

But the issue hasn't caught officialdom's attention yet. The freeze on the grants to these universities was issued in 1998 and more than 12 years later it still exists despite the university officials running from pillar to post, first in the Mulayam Singh Yadav era

(2003-07) and since then in the Mayawati age. "We have been compelled to take to recourse to strikes and agitations after fighting for years," says Pratap Singh, adding that the demands also include implementation of the sixth pay panel report and promotion of teaching and non-teaching staff.

Ironically, the state Government has still not lifted the freeze order but is magnanimously sanctioning funds for new construction projects. "A new agriculture university has been sanctioned in Banda district and Rs 300 crore have been sanctioned for similar work at NDATU. The hidden agenda behind the sanctioning is to make money and commission from these projects," alleges Pratap Singh.

While the Government and the scientists and teachers fight it out, the biggest losers are farmers in India's most populous state. ■



"Hundreds were appointed in an irregular manner and some V-Cs were involved in money making."

SHASHANK S. SINGH, Cabinet Secretary